

Knowledge, Knower, and Known in Madhyasth Darshan

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The question: What is knowledge, who is the knower, and what is it that one can know? How do we ground these concepts in experience, and how does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with the non-dualism of Advaita Vedanta and the physicalism of modern science and philosophy?

This study explores these questions from three paradigms: **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), **Advaita Vedanta**, and **Modern Science / Philosophy** — then compares and critically reviews all three.

Quick Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
<i>Jeevan</i>	The sentient self — in Shri Nagraj's view a real, eternal, atom-scale entity that works <i>through</i> the body.
<i>Drishta-pad</i> (Seer status)	The unique capacity of the human being in existence to observe, understand, and evaluate all orders of nature.
<i>Darshan-drishya-drishhti</i>	Madhyasth Darshan's structure of worldview, scene, and perspective: the perceiver uses perspective to see the real scene and arrive at holistic understanding.
<i>Gyan-vivek-vigyan</i>	Knowledge, wisdom/discrimination, and science/systematic know-how — the way understanding becomes evaluation and practical participation.
Coexistence (<i>sah-astitva</i>)	Existence seen as all units inseparably present together in Space.
<i>Atman</i> / * Brahman *	In Advaita Vedanta: the innermost Self / the one ultimate, non-dual reality.
<i>Mithya</i>	Advaita's term for the world: dependent, provisional appearance, not absolutely real.
Hard Problem	The mystery of why physical brain processes are accompanied by subjective, felt experience at all.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

The claim in one sentence: Knowledge is the realization of coexistence evidenced as wisdom, science, and humane conduct; the knower is the active sentient self (*jeevan*) operating through the human body in seer-status (*drishta-pad*); and the knowable is existence itself — Omnipresence and all real units in their relationships, orderliness, and conduct.

What is Knowledge?

According to Shri A. Nagraj, knowledge (*gyan*) is not a subjective construct, a private mental state, or a mere collection of information. It has an ontological base, an epistemic structure, and a practical test.

1. Space itself is Knowledge. In its ultimate sense, Space (*shunya / vyapak*) is not empty nothingness. It is omnipresent, transparent, all-pervasive, and the uniform energy in which all units are saturated. This omnipresent Space is itself Knowledge:

“Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space.” — MVD, p. 35

“The Space (Omnipresence) itself is knowledge. Omnipresence itself is Omnipotence.” — MVD, p. 143

“Space itself is knowledge, knowledge itself is Omnipresence,” — MVD, p. 155

This should not be confused with Advaita’s Brahman or with modern panpsychism. In Madhyasth Darshan, Space is not an individual conscious subject and not a unit among other units. It is the omnipresent, non-transforming medium in which all material (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units are submerged, energised, regulated, and conserved. The sentient knower is still *jeevan*, not Space itself.

2. Knowledge unfolds as *gyan-vivek-vigyan*. When realized by the human being, knowledge becomes evident as wisdom and science, not as belief alone:

“The realisation in coexistence itself is the unfolding of knowledge. The study is in, by and for realisation in coexistence. Knowledge itself is evident in the form of wisdom and science.” — MVD, p. 35

This gives Madhyasth Darshan a distinctive epistemic structure:

1. ***Gyan*** — understanding reality as coexistence.

2. **Vivek** — wisdom/discrimination that evaluates life by justice, dharma, and truth rather than only pleasure, health, and profit.
3. **Vigyan** — science or systematic knowledge that enables right experiment, production, and participation in orderliness.

Thus knowledge is not only contemplative. It must become correct perspective, correct evaluation, and correct practical participation.

3. The Threefold Content of Complete Knowledge. In human life, knowledge has three inseparable areas:

“1. Knowledge of jeevan 2. Knowledge of holistic view of existence 3. Knowledge of humane conduct” — SB, p. 116

To have complete knowledge (*paripoorna gyan*) means to understand the nature of the self (*jeevan*), the structure of existence as coexistence (*sah-astitva*), and how to live in harmony with other humans and nature (humane conduct).

4. Worldview, Scene, and Perspective (*darshan-drishya-drishti*). Madhyasth Darshan does not begin from a detached subject staring at external objects. It describes a perceiver using a perspective to see the scene, and the successful accomplishment of this process is understanding:

“The activity and process that a perceiver uses through their perspective for seeing the scene itself is worldview, the accomplishment from which is the understanding or knowledge.” — MVD, p. 84

Here:

1. **Drishya (scene)** is the world of activities — existence as it appears in the present.
2. **Drishti (perspective)** is the act of seeing, understanding, recognizing, and evaluating realities.
3. **Darshan (worldview / holistic view)** is the accomplished understanding obtained through right perspective.

This is a key difference from both comparison partners. Advaita’s *drig-drishya* analysis uses seer-seen discrimination to negate the seen and arrive at the actionless witness. Madhyasth Darshan instead asks whether the human’s perspective can become aligned with coexistence so that the scene is understood as it is and then evidenced in conduct. Modern science, by contrast, privileges third-person observation and public modelling; Madhyasth Darshan also demands evidence, but includes first-person realization and value-fulfilment in relationships as part of that evidence.

5. Knowing, Believing, Recognizing, and Fulfilling. Knowledge is expressed dynamically in human behavior through four interconnected activities: *janna* (knowing), *manna* (believing), *pahchanna* (recognizing), and *nirvaha karna* (fulfilling):

“What is knowledge? Knowing and believing constitute knowledge.” —
JV, p. 165

In a deluded human, believing is separated from knowing (believing without knowing). In an awakened human, they are unified:

“Believe what is known Know what is believed” — *MVD, p. 12*

When we *know* existence as coexistence and *believe* in this reality, we spontaneously *recognize* our relationships with all units in nature and *fulfill* our values (justice, trust, cooperation) in behavior.

6. The evidence chain: realization, behavior, experiment. Madhyasth Darshan’s test of knowledge is not private conviction alone. The text gives a practical evidence chain:

“Realisation – Behaviour – Experiment” — *MVD, p. 12*

“Realisation itself is the ultimate evidence, Evidence itself is the understanding or knowledge, Understanding itself is manifest, The manifest itself is resolution, work and behaviour, Work and behaviour itself is evidence, Evidence itself is awakened tradition, Awakened tradition itself is coexistence.” — *MVD, p. 12*

This is why humane conduct is not an ethical appendix to knowledge. It is part of the verification of knowledge. If a person claims to know coexistence but cannot evidence resolution, justice, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence in living, the knowledge has not yet become complete evidence.

7. Realization (*anubhuti*). Ultimate knowledge is direct realization in coexistence, but this realization is expected to become visible in thought, behavior, and experiment:

“The realisation in coexistence itself is the complete knowledge.” — MVD, p. 116

“Realisation in knowledge (gyan-anubhuti): - Realisation in the ultimate truth” — MVD, p. 316

“delusion-less knowledge (nirbhram gyan): - Knowing, understanding and imparting the understanding of the realities the way they are.” — MVD, p. 317

Who is the Knower?

The knower (*gyata* or *drishta*) is the sentient self — **jeevan** — operating through the human body. Specifically, the human being is the locus where seer-status can be evidenced:

“The noteworthy points here are: 1. In coexistence, the human being is integrally and indivisibly present. 2. In existence, the human being is a seer (observer).” — SB, p. 188

“The human being alone is the seer-status in existence.” — SB, p. 239

Material things (like stones) and biological organisms (like plants) do not have the capacity to know. Animals have sensory awareness and react to pain or pleasure, but they cannot evaluate existence. Only the human being belongs to the **knowledge order** (*gyan avastha*) and has the capacity of understanding. However, this capacity must be awakened:

“Only awakened humans are recognisable in the seer status.” — MVD, p. 33

This distinction is important: every human has the possibility of seer-status because every human has imagination, freedom of action, and the capacity for understanding; only the awakened human evidences that status in living.

The knower in Madhyasth Darshan is therefore not an actionless, passive witness. *Jeevan* is an active, structured, sentient unit. Its activities include hope in *mun*, thought in *vrutti*, desire in *chitta*, resoluteness in *buddhi*, and realization in *atma*. The body is the instrument through which this *jeevan* acts; the brain (*medhas*) receives and processes signals related to *jeevan*’s aspirations, desires, and evidence (MVD, p. 83). This makes Madhyasth Darshan sharply different from Advaita: the inner self is not finally negated into an actionless witness, but understood as a real, active, constitutionally complete unit capable of awakening.

It also differs from modern physicalism. Modern neuroscience treats mind as brain activity. Madhyasth Darshan treats the brain as a bodily organ through which *jeevan* operates, and treats values and evaluation as activities of *jeevan*, not mechanical outputs of the body.

What is the Knowable (the Known)?

The knowable (*gyeya*) is **existence itself in the form of coexistence**. It includes Omnipresence and all units saturated in it:

“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.” — MVD, p. 11

Therefore, to know something in Madhyasth Darshan is not merely to measure its external properties. It is to understand its form (*roop*), properties (*gun*), essential nature (*svabhav*), dharma, relationships, value, and participation in overall orderliness. The knowable includes:

1. **The Four Orders of Nature:** The material order (*padarth avastha*), biological order (*pran avastha*), animal order (*jeev avastha*), and knowledge order (*gyan avastha*).
2. **Omnipresence and Units:** Space as the omnipresent medium, and all countable units saturated in it.
3. **The Laws of Nature:** Effort, motion, result, balance, integration, development, awakening, and participation in overall orderliness.
4. **Relationships and Values:** The mutual expectations through which units participate in one another.
5. **Humane Conduct:** Justice, values, evaluation, mutual satisfaction, resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence in human life.

Crucially, in Madhyasth Darshan, the known world is **absolutely real and perpetual** (*nitya*). It is not an illusion or a temporary mistake:

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” — MVD, *The Alternative*, point 8

This is the most direct contrast with Advaita Vedanta. Advaita resolves the knower-known distinction by sublating the known world into Brahman. Madhyasth Darshan resolves it by awakening the knower to the real coexistence of Omnipresence and world. The world is not negated; it is understood, recognized, and fulfilled in conduct.

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

The claim in one sentence: The true knower is the actionless witness Self (*Atman* / *sakshi*), which is identical to the ultimate reality (*Brahman*); the known world of diversity is a dependent appearance (*mithya*); and knowledge is the direct realization of this non-duality, dissolving the distinction between knower, known, and knowing.

The Seer and the Seen (*Drig-Drishya*)

Advaita Vedanta begins its inquiry by separating the Seer (*drig*) from the Seen (*drishya*). The fundamental rule of this discrimination (*viveka*) is that whatever is observed cannot be the observer:

“The form... is perceived and the eye... is its perceiver... It... is perceived and the mind... is its perceiver. The mind with... modifications is perceived and the Witness (the Self) is verily the perceiver... But... is not perceived...” — DDV, p. 15

Following this logic, the physical body is seen (observed), so it is not the Seer. Senses, emotions, and thoughts are also witnessed by the mind, so they are not the ultimate Seer. The ultimate Seer is the **Witness Consciousness** (*sakshi-caitanya* / *Atman*). This witness is never an object of perception; it is the ultimate subject:

“There are two things which are different from each other. They are the seer and the seen. The seer is Brahman and the seen is mAyA.” — BJM, v. 17

The Nature of the Knower

In absolute reality (*paramartha*), Brahman is one, without a second (*ekamevaditiam*, CU 6.2.1). Therefore, there cannot be multiple, separate individual knowers. The individual knower (*jiva* or *ahamkara*) is a provisional appearance arising due to ignorance (*avidya*).

This happens through **superimposition** (*adhyasa*): we superimpose the qualities of the physical body and mind (like “I am tall,” “I am sad”) onto the Self, and we superimpose the self-luminous consciousness of the Self onto the inert body-mind complex. The true Self is actionless (*akriya*) and does not do anything (BSB, *Adhyasa Bhashya*).

The Nature of the Known

The known universe of diversity (objects, space, time, individuals) is **not absolutely real**. It is categorized as *mithya* — meaning it has dependent reality (like a clay pot which is nothing but clay, or a wave which is nothing but water):

“The pot, wall, etc., are all nothing but clay. Likewise, the entire universe is nothing but Brahman.” — *BJM*, v. 19

“Brahman is real, the universe is mithya, and the jiva is Brahman itself and not different.” — *BJM*, v. 20

The world appears real only as long as ignorance persists; once Brahman is realized, the world is sublated (*badhita*), and only Brahman remains.

3. The Modern Scientific and Philosophical View

The claim in one sentence: The knower is a biological organism (human) whose brain processes generate the mind; the known is the physical universe of matter and energy; and knowledge is structured information validated by empirical testing, falsification, and intersubjective consensus.

What is Knowledge?

In modern science and analytical philosophy, knowledge is typically defined as **justified true belief** (in classical epistemology) or as **predictive modeling** (in cognitive science and naturalism). 1. **Methodological Naturalism:** Knowledge is obtained by formulating hypotheses about the physical world and testing them against empirical evidence (Popper 1959). It requires intersubjective verification: anyone must be able to replicate the results using the same instruments. 2. **Information Processing:** The brain builds neural networks that model the properties and behaviors of the environment (Kandel et al. 2021). These models are updated based on sensory feedback to optimize survival and action.

Who is the Knower?

Mainstream physicalist accounts in modern science and philosophy reject the existence of any eternal, non-physical soul, *jeevan*, or *Atman*. 1. **The Brain as the Mind:** Consciousness and the sense of self are emergent properties of complex neuronal systems (Dennett 1991; Churchland 1986). There is no “cartesian theater” or separate observer inside the brain; the self is a cognitive construct or illusion generated by the brain’s integration of sensory data. 2. **Causal Closure of the Physical:** The physical universe is causally closed, meaning that every physical event (such as a muscle moving) is entirely caused by preceding

physical events (such as motor neurons firing). There is no room for a non-physical entity (*jeevan* or *Atman*) to inject energy or intention into the nervous system (Kim 2005).

What can be Known?

The knowable is the objective, physical universe of matter, energy, space, and time. Claims that cannot be publicly observed, measured, mathematically modeled, or indirectly inferred through successful prediction remain outside established scientific knowledge.

However, this third-person objective method leaves open the **Hard Problem of Consciousness**: why and how should physical brain processes give rise to subjective, first-person experiences (Chalmers 1995; Nagel 1974)? Some modern philosophers take seriously the idea of *panpsychism* (consciousness is a fundamental property of matter) or *realistic monism* (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019), but these remain speculative interpretations rather than mainstream scientific findings.

4. Comparing the Three Views

Comparative Matrix

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Science & Philosophy
What is Knowledge?	Realization of coexistence, unfolding as <i>gyan-vivek-vigyan</i> and humane conduct	Direct realization of Atman-Brahman identity; non-dual awareness (<i>jnana-svarupa</i>)	Justified true belief; predictive neural models of physical reality
Who is the Knower?	Active sentient <i>jeevan</i> operating through the body; human evidences seer-status (<i>drishta-pad</i>)	Actionless Witness Self (<i>Atman / sakshi</i>); individual knower (<i>jiva</i>) is provisionally real but ultimately sublated	Evolved biological organism (brain-mind complex); the “self” is an emergent cognitive construct
What is the Known?	Existence as coexistence: Omnipresence, all units, four orders, relationships, values, humane conduct	The empirical world (<i>drishya</i>), ultimately <i>mithya</i> (dependent appearance)	The objective physical universe (matter, energy, space, time)
Basic Structure	<i>Darshan-drishya-drishti</i> : right perspective sees the real scene and becomes holistic view	<i>Drig-drishya-viveka</i> : seer-seen discrimination negates the seen to reveal the witness	Subject-object modelling: observer builds public, testable models of objects/events
Is the World Real?	Yes. “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”	Provisionally (<i>vyavaharika</i>), yes; absolutely (<i>paramarthika</i>), no.	Yes, for scientific realism and physicalism; methodologically, it is treated as publicly observable and law-governed.
Method of Knowing	Study, self-verification, realization-behavior-experiment, and evidence in conduct	Scripture (<i>shravana</i>), reasoning (<i>manana</i>), and meditation (<i>nididhyasana</i>)	Observation, experiment, mathematical modeling, prediction, and replication

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Science & Philosophy
Status of Ethics	Humane conduct is part of complete knowledge and its evidence	Ethics purifies the mind and operates within provisional reality	Ethics is explained through evolution, psychology, social contract, or human values
Life's Purpose	Awakening: resolution, prosperity, harmony, and coexistence in society	Liberation (<i>moksha</i>): freedom from birth and death by realizing identity with Brahman	Biological survival, adaptation, and human-constructed meaning

Key Contrasts

- 1. Reality of the World:** Advaita Vedanta treats the world as *mithya* — provisionally valid but not absolutely real — to safeguard the absolute non-duality of Brahman. Madhyasth Darshan rejects this, asserting that both Brahma (Space) and the world (material and sentient units) are real: *Brahma satya, jagat nitya*. Modern science also affirms the reality of the physical world, but does not accept Space as omnipresent knowledge.
- 2. Two Different Seer-Scene Structures:** Advaita's *drig-drishya* method separates the seer from the seen and keeps negating the seen until only the actionless witness remains. Madhyasth Darshan's *darshan-drishya-drishti* structure asks whether the human perspective can see the scene as coexistence and then evidence that understanding in conduct. Modern science treats the observer as a biological system that constructs public models of observable events.
- 3. Active vs. Passive Knower:** In Advaita, the true Self is an actionless witness (*sakshi / akriya*). In Madhyasth Darshan, the knower (*jeevan*) is active, possessing structure, hope, thought, desire, evaluation, and the capacity for realization. In modern science, the knower is a dynamic, evolving biological system.
- 4. Knowledge Must Become Conduct:** In Madhyasth Darshan, *gyan* must unfold as *vivek* and *vigyan*, and then become evident through realization, behavior, and experiment. Advaita's highest knowledge culminates in liberation from mistaken identification. Modern science's knowledge culminates in predictive control, explanation, and replicable models.
- 5. The Status of Space:** In modern physics, space-time is a physical structure described mathematically. In Advaita, space (*akasha*) belongs to the order of appearance and is therefore *mithya*. In Madhyasth Darshan, Space (*shunya / vyapak*) is eternal, omnipresent, all-pervasive knowledge and energy itself, but not an individual conscious unit.

5. Critical Review

5.1 Madhyasth Darshan

- **Strengths:** It offers a realistic, positive framework that validates human relationships, ethics, and ecological balance as absolutely real. Its structure is unusually integrated: ontology (Space and units), epistemology (*darshan-drishya-drishti*), self-knowledge (*jeevan*), practical wisdom (*gyan-vivek-vigyan*), and conduct are all tied to one evidence chain. It avoids Advaita's difficult task of explaining how a dependent world feels so real, and it avoids the "combination problem" of panpsychism by defining the self as a single, indivisible, constitutionally complete atom.
- **Weaknesses:**
 - **Axiomatic Foundations:** The claim that "Space is Knowledge" is a metaphysical assertion that cannot be verified by physical measurement.
 - **The Interaction Problem:** If the *jeevan* is a sentient atom operating through the body, the account needs a clearer bridge between *jeevan*'s signals and the brain's measurable neural processes. Madhyasth Darshan names the brain (*medhas*) as the receiver of *jeevan*'s signals, but this remains hard to reconcile with physical causal closure.
 - **Falsifiability:** The system risks being unfalsifiable because any disagreement or failure to verify its claims is attributed to a "lack of awakening" rather than a possible error in the theory.

5.2 Advaita Vedanta

- **Strengths:** It is highly rigorous and start from the most undeniable fact of human existence: first-person consciousness itself. Its method of negating the observed to find the observer (*neti neti*) is a powerful introspective practice.
- **Weaknesses:**
 - **The Status of Ethics:** If the world and individuality are ultimately unreal (*mithya*), then ethical action and human suffering also have only provisional value. This makes it difficult to build a robust foundation for social and ecological responsibility.
 - **The Ignorance Paradox:** If only Brahman exists and is pure knowledge, where does the ignorance (*avidya*) that creates the illusion of the world come from? Advaita's explanation that ignorance is "indescribable" (*anirvacaniya*) is often criticized as a logical evasion.

5.3 Modern Science & Philosophy

- **Strengths:** It has delivered unmatched predictive power, medicine, and technology. Its self-correcting methodology of replication and peer review is the most successful system for eliminating subjective bias.
 - **Weaknesses:**
 - **The Hard Problem:** Science has failed to explain how objective, physical brain processes (like neurons firing) can produce subjective, qualitative experience (like seeing red or feeling love).
 - **First-Person Blindness:** By ruling out first-person subjective experience as valid evidence, science ignores the very medium through which all scientific observations are made.
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6. References

All sources cited in this document, grouped by tradition. Each entry begins with the bold tag used in the text.

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